

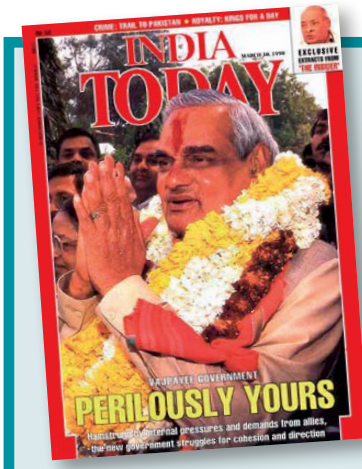
COALITION ERA

FRAGMENTS OF A VISION

Rao, Gowda, Gujral, three times Vajpayee, and then Manmohan. In an era of fragile coalitions, India found a new synthesis in Vajpayee

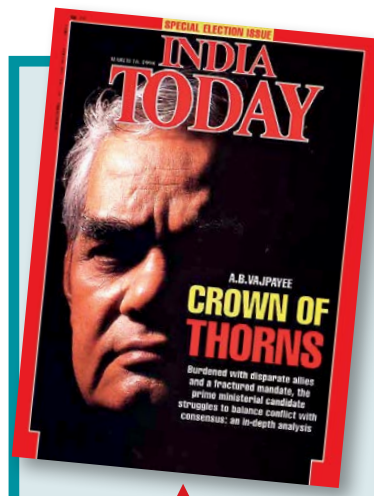
Taking 1995-2005 at face value, it may appear as if a capricious higher power was in charge—dealing out a dizzying series of ultra-fast sleights of hand. Narasimha Rao was still there as things began, but facing the exit door and, after him, came six more prime ministerial swearing-ins, featuring four faces: H.D. Deve Gowda, I.K. Gujral, A.B. Vajpayee and Manmohan Singh. The Rao regime wasn't exactly the paragon of rock-solid stability, being a minority government taunted by no-trust motions, but it was canny enough to survive for five years. Net net, that meant India was still used to a certain inertia of rest in New Delhi. But this decade is when the law of averages caught up.

Vajpayee had the first stab at it. Ayodhya had given the BJP quite a boost, and it made its first heavy lift at the Centre. It was the single largest party, but a fragmented mandate meant it didn't have the numbers to make it stick. Vajpayee's first term lasted only 13 days. Who would fill the void amid this swirling, majority-less churn? There was an embarrassment of riches when it came to potential prime ministers. After V.P. Singh demurred, the Left too held back on Jyoti Basu.



Perilously Yours
Mar. 30, 1998

"The question that haunts an increasingly frazzled Vajpayee is: will he be a captive prime minister? Captive to the extortionism of some insatiable ally? Captive to sectional pressures within his own party? Certainly, there is no question—as the Jaswant Singh and Jayalalitha episodes revealed—of Vajpayee being a completely free agent."



Crown of Thorns
Mar. 16, 1998

"Even if the numbers don't add up for the BJP at present, the prospects of forging an anti-BJP combine are even more daunting. No party wants to be seen hijacking the mandate by denying Vajpayee a stint in South Block. "We are not in a hurry" is the present refrain of even those Congress and UF leaders who initially reacted in panic to the news of the BJP's near-victory."